necessities like a refrigerator or air conditioner weren't affordable. Yet Rohini made our home comfortable, and gave it an artistic touch with a minimalistic look. Till she put up her paintings and sketches, I never knew that she was a good artist. She had held her painting exhibition at Bal Gandharva Rang Mandir in Poona a few months before our wedding. Later she told me that she had studied art at Academie Julian in Paris, when her father was posted there as the military attaché in our embassy from 1966 to 1969. As a teenager, she had travelled all over Europe during their three-year stay in Paris. Earlier, as a child, she had lived in Kabul, when her father did a stint as the defence attaché in our mission in Afghanistan. With all her foreign travels and exposure to the advanced countries, I sometimes wondered how she would take to living with an infantry man. To our credit, we made it work, though it was tough.

We are both fond of the outdoors and sports. When we were about to be married, she asked me very innocently, 'I hope you don't play bridge or golf.'

'I do,' was my frank response. When she asked me to give up these games, we made a deal. I would not play bridge provided she joined me in golf. We have kept our word. We are avid golfers and surprisingly, enjoy playing together. I find golf a great stress-buster.

It was during this period that I received a communication from the Army HQ asking me to report for the pre-Everest expedition trials at the Himalayan Mountaineering Institute, Darjeeling. Having done well in the basic and advanced courses, I felt I could make it to the Everest expedition if I volunteered. But in that case, my life thereafter might have been that of a mountaineer. When I asked Rohini for her advice, her response was that I should carefully analyse the pros and cons and then decide. Further, she conveyed that she would respect my decision. As it happened, I decided to continue soldiering. Importantly, I also continued to enjoy the mountains while serving at the northern borders along the great Himalayas.